

the pass. Astonishingly Chávez made it across the mountains in his frail machine and headed down to land at the Italian town of Domodossola, 41 minutes after takeoff. But as he glided down to the landing place, his monoplane suddenly plunged into the ground, crushing the pilot in the wreckage. Chávez was gravely injured and died four days later in the hospital. His heroism made him a legend in Europe – poetry was dedicated to his “sublime death” – but

his crash has never been adequately explained. One theory is that he had become so numbed by cold flying over the Alps that he could not operate the controls and let the aircraft stall. Alternatively, the Blériot’s flimsy airframe may have collapsed under the cumulative strains of the high-altitude flight.

The cost of flying

The tolerance of injury and loss of life in the early days of flying was often, to a modern view, remarkable. In 1911, a series of long-distance races was arranged in Europe, proving the occasion for some horrendous accidents. The competitors in the Paris–Madrid air race, held in

May, took off from Issy-les-Moulineaux

outside Paris, in front of a crowd estimated at 300,000. Conditions were chaotic and takeoffs were repeatedly impeded by groups of people wandering in front of the flying machines. Among those far too close to the action was a clutch of French politicians and officials, including prime minister Ernest Monice and minister for war Maurice Bertaux. Unsurprisingly, one of the aircraft got into difficulties, suffering a sudden loss of power. The pilot, Emile Train, swerving to avoid a troop of cavalry, plunged straight into the crowd of dignitaries. The minister for war was killed outright and the prime minister was seriously injured, along with some 50 other spectators. Despite this incident, the race was restarted the following day and proceeded as planned. After a welter of crash-landings and mechanical failures, only one aviator reached Madrid, Frenchman Jules Védrines, who instantly joined the thickening ranks of aviator-celebrities.

The start of another race that year, the Circuit-of-Europe, held in June, brought further carnage. Three pilots

suffered horrifying crashes on takeoff: two were killed – one burned to death in full view of the stands – and the other was crippled, losing both his legs. Yet the race was not canceled, continuing for three weeks on a circuit that covered over 1,000 miles (1,600km) from Paris through Brussels

and London and back to Paris again. It was won by another Frenchman, Jean Conneau. Huge excitement was generated by these contests between the “magnificent men in their flying machines.” When a tightly fought encounter in July saw the

popular Védrines finish runner-up to Conneau in the Circuit-of-Britain race, thousands of pounds were raised by public subscription to compensate Védrines for missing the winner’s cash prize.

While these long, competitive flights did not necessarily confirm the potential practicability of aircraft as commercial or military machines, it

“Arriba, siempre arriba.”
(Higher, always higher.)

JORGE CHAVEZ

CHAVEZ’S REPORTED DYING WORDS –
NOW THE MOTTO OF THE PERUVIAN AIR FORCE

